

Key Findings

- **Overall performance:** Catering sales for 2026 YTD totalled £14.42m, a year-on-year increase of 8.8% against the equivalent 2025 period. This growth decomposes into a 6.6% rise in transaction volume and a 5.4% rise in passenger throughput, alongside a 2.1% increase in average transaction value. The composition of this growth — volume and value both contributing positively — indicates that the increase in sales is not attributable to a single factor, but reflects concurrent gains in customer footfall, conversion, and spend per transaction.
- **Passenger traffic as a driver, not a determinant.** Passenger volume correlates positively with both sales and transaction counts, confirming its role as a primary demand driver. However, month-on-month divergence between passenger growth rates, transaction growth rates, and average transaction value indicates that passenger throughput is not a sufficient explanatory variable on its own. The estate's conversion efficiency — its ability to translate footfall into completed purchases — introduces variance that passenger figures alone do not account for and should be treated as a distinct commercial factor.
- **Concentration of contribution: North Kitchen.** North Kitchen is the estate's largest single contributor, generating approximately £8.15m in YTD sales — 56.5% of total catering revenue — from approximately 545,540 transactions. This share reflects a combination of high transaction throughput and a comparatively large unit footprint, rather than either factor in isolation.
- **Outlet-level divergence.** Performance at the outlet level is heterogeneous, with growth or decline attributable to differing combinations of transaction volume and average transaction value: Oak Coffee Bar, +25.3% YTD sales growth; Gate Bistro (–12.0% YTD sales); Terminal Kitchen, –13.3% YTD sales
- Sky Deli: +99.1% YTD sales growth — this figure warrants cautious interpretation, as the prior-year comparison period is incomplete and therefore not fully like-for-like.
- **Data quality observations.** The review identified two average-transaction-value outliers meriting flag status. The most material instance is Terminal Kitchen, August 2024, where approximately £5.16m in sales from approximately 38,398 transactions yields an average transaction value of approximately £134.41 — substantially above the estate norm. The underlying source value has been retained rather than amended, as there is no independent basis to correct it. Consequently, any analysis incorporating historic sales data should be run both including and excluding the flagged observations, to test the sensitivity of conclusions to this anomaly.

Assumptions and Limitations

- Missing outlet-months are treated as data gaps (no available record), not as periods of zero sales.

- Passenger figures reflect total airport passenger volume and may not correspond to footfall at individual outlet locations.
- Transactions are counted as completed purchases, not unique customers; repeat purchases by the same customer are not distinguished.
- Statistical correlation between passengers, transactions, and sales is descriptive only and does not establish causation.
- A threshold of £50 sales-per-transaction was used to flag rows for review. This threshold is a screening heuristic, not a determination of error.
- The Sky Deli year-on-year comparison is not fully like-for-like, owing to incomplete prior-year data.
- Candidate explanations involving pricing, opening hours, weather, construction, or outlet location are hypotheses only; the dataset does not contain the information required to verify causal mechanisms.